

states JAMMU AND KASHMIR

leaders feel that the only solution is that the Government should hand back the land to the Shri Amarnath Shrine Board (SASB). In the end, it was decided that an all-party delegation would visit the strife-torn region. On the other side, the PDP too refused to tone down its opposition to the land allotment. After all, everyone was aware that the state is slated to go to the polls in over two months and each party was appealing to its own votebank.

There is simply no denying that, on the eve of the crucial state elections, the Congress is juggling a political hot potato following its flip-flop over the land transfer. Yet blame cannot be laid solely at former chief minister Ghulam Nabi Azad's door, as the decision to revoke the land transfer was taken at the behest of the current governor, N.N. Vohra. Since the governor is a nominee of the Government at the Centre, questions have been raised about the kind of directions issued by the Prime Minister's Office, the Home ministry and 10, Janpath. After losing face over the Ram Setu flip-flop, the Congress knows all too well that it can ill-afford to play with the sentiments of the majority community. More so, it does not want to be projected as an anti-Hindu party as four states in north India are slated for polls after Jammu and Kashmir. Yet it has done just that. As a worried Congress general secretary wondered, "Are we making the same mistake we did in opening the locks of the Babri Masjid?"

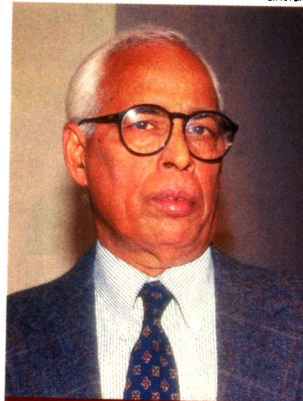
It was on May 26 that Azad transferred 100 acres of forest land to the SASB, a move spearheaded by the then governor and head of the board S.K. Sinha, and decided to erect facilities for the pilgrims to the holy cave. Despite the fact that the then forest minister Qazi Muhammad Afzal belongs to the PDP and was party to the cabinet decision to transfer the land, PDP chief Mehbooba Mufti withdrew support to the government on June 28. Three days later, the state's new governor, Vohra, wrote to Azad saying that the board no longer needed the land. Instead, he suggested that the government should be given charge of pilgrimage logistics. Sensing that Vohra's directions were prompted by the central leadership in Delhi, Azad's cabinet revoked the land allotment order but

UNFINISHED BUSINESS: The all-party meeting in Delhi; (below, from left) Vohra, Mehbooba, Azad and Omar



SIPRA DAS

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Nearly two months before the troubled state goes to

despite this, PDP refused to be won over and Azad resigned without facing the trust vote on July 7. State Congress leaders say that the PDP was looking for an issue to distance itself from the Congress government, since most of its hardline policies had been ignored. It could not have got a better issue than the Amarnath shrine land allotment.

There is another part to the context here. By July, the Government had decided to go ahead with the nuclear deal and was desperately scouring for numbers. But if the strategy was to appease the single MP from PDP and two National Conference (NC) MPs by revoking the order in the backdrop of a possible trust vote, then it clearly

backfired. Jammu has been plunged into month-long turmoil with protesters reviving demands for separate statehood for the region. Suddenly, as Rajnath pointed out, a local issue has become a grave national concern. No wonder that Sonia and Manmohan were worried enough to turn to their political opponents for help.

Before the all-party meeting, Congress strategists debated various suggestions, including one put forward by the NC that the land be given to SASB for the pilgrimage period and then reverted to the state Tourism Department after it ends. Rajnath also pointed out that the Congress was on the verge of repeating the 1987 Shah